

R-Anchors and the Architecture of Argumenthood

Abstract

Arguments occupy a central place in syntactic theory, yet their status as grammatical objects is rarely made explicit. Across frameworks, argument positions are presupposed and diagnosed through thematic roles, case, or agreement. When these diagnostics fail, discourse-based mechanisms are often invoked as an alternative. As a result, phenomena such as argument omission, generic interpretation, and persistent ambiguity are typically treated as exceptional rather than as expected consequences of grammatical structure.

This paper develops a minimal architectural reanalysis of argumenthood. It proposes that predicates do not directly combine with arguments but project abstract dependency objects, referred to as 'R-anchors'. These objects represent dependency existence independently of overt realization and independently of referential identification. Elements that introduce referential material are assumed to instantiate the same basic object type, differing only in how they enter the grammatical representation.

On this view, what is traditionally described as an argument emerges only if a predicate-projected dependency is structurally completed by a single grammatical operation, Anchor-Checking. This operation relates already existing dependency objects without introducing new argumental material and without enforcing uniqueness.

Crucially, this proposal does not multiply grammatical objects. It replaces a family of argument-related primitives with a single dependency format and a single completion operation. As a consequence, apparent omission, genericity, and structural ambiguity follow as licensed outcomes of grammatical structure rather than as repairs or defaults. Established notions such as case and agreement are retained descriptively but reinterpreted as reflexes of dependency completion rather than as sources of argument existence.

The proposal is conceptually grounded in work on R-loci in sign languages, where the separation between dependency structure and referential anchoring is particularly transparent, but the resulting architecture is intended to be modality-neutral.

1. Introduction: The Problem of Argumenthood

Arguments are among the most familiar objects of syntactic theory. Predicates are assumed to stand in argument relations, and grammatical structure is routinely described in terms of how these relations are realized and interpreted. Yet despite their centrality, the grammatical status of arguments themselves is rarely made explicit. What it means, in grammatical terms, for an argument-related dependency to exist is usually taken for granted rather than independently represented.

This assumption is not accidental. A large body of theoretical work has been devoted to explaining how argument-related dependencies behave once they are in place. Case, agreement, and other morphosyntactic mechanisms successfully capture patterns of realization and interaction, while discourse-based approaches account for how reference is recovered and maintained. What unifies these otherwise diverse perspectives is a shared architectural assumption: argument positions are presupposed as part of grammatical structure. Syntactic mechanisms operate over them, but their existence is inferred from their effects rather than made explicit in the representation.

Treating argumenthood as given has systematic consequences. Across languages, dependencies introduced by predicates may remain underdetermined without compromising grammaticality. Interpretation may be stable even where reference is not uniquely fixed. Such configurations are therefore often treated as secondary or exceptional, as if they reflected deviations from a more basic, fully specified norm.

What is striking, however, is that these cases do not pattern like genuine failures of grammatical licensing. Underspecification, generic interpretation, and structural ambiguity recur across constructions and languages, and they do so in highly systematic ways. Their treatment as exceptional

typically rests on the assumption that arguments are expected to surface in stable, canonically associated positions. Once this expectation is relaxed, the need for special repair mechanisms becomes less compelling. The difficulty appears to lie not in the phenomena themselves, but in the architectural background against which they are evaluated.

The present paper approaches this issue from a different angle. Rather than asking how arguments are licensed or interpreted under particular conditions, it asks what kind of grammatical object an argument position *is* in the first place. More specifically, it asks whether argumenthood is an independent primitive of grammatical representation, or whether it emerges from the resolution of more basic structural dependencies. Framed in this way, the problem is architectural rather than descriptive.

Evidence for such a distinction is already implicit in standard analytical practice. In the analysis of spoken languages, abstract indices are routinely used to track identity across syntactic positions. These indices support the formal treatment of dependency relations even where no overt marking is available. At the same time, they are typically regarded as notational devices rather than as objects with grammatical status. Sign languages make the same underlying distinction more visible. There, reference is tracked through spatial loci that persist across discourse and interact directly with verbal structure, allowing dependency existence and referential identification to be observed as separable components. The contrast is thus one of visibility, not of kind.

Taken together, these considerations motivate a shift in perspective. If dependency existence and referential identification can come apart, then arguments cannot be primitives of grammatical structure. Instead, predicates must be assumed to introduce abstract dependencies that persist independently of how they are eventually anchored in reference. Whether such dependencies come to function as arguments depends on how, and under which conditions, they are structurally resolved.

The proposal developed in this paper makes this assumption explicit. It introduces a minimal class of grammatical objects—referred to as R-anchors—that represent argument-related dependencies as such. These objects mediate between predicate structure and reference. Crucially, the architecture is uniform: dependencies projected by predicates and elements that introduce referential material instantiate the same basic object type and differ only in their informational specification. This shift collapses a range of distinctions traditionally encoded in separate mechanisms into a single dependency format. What varies is not the type of grammatical object involved, but the informational state in which it enters the derivation. Argumenthood, on this view, is not projected but emerges when a dependency is structurally completed.

The aim of the present paper is not to propose a new typology of argument-related phenomena or to replace established descriptive mechanisms. Rather, it seeks to make explicit the minimal architectural commitments required to represent dependency existence in the grammar. Familiar notions such as case, agreement, and discourse reference are not rejected. They are reinterpreted as mechanisms that operate over dependencies whose existence is grounded elsewhere.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 develops a diagnostic review of existing approaches, consolidating substantive insights across otherwise divergent frameworks. It also shows that, despite this convergence, argument existence is presupposed rather than explicitly modeled. Section 3 introduces a dependency-based architecture and motivates the notion of R-anchors as the relevant grammatical objects. The subsequent sections elaborate on this architecture, specify how dependencies are completed, and explore the consequences of this system for omission, generic interpretation, and structural ambiguity. The final section situates the proposal within a broader theoretical perspective and clarifies its scope.

2. Diagnostics of Argumenthood

Argument-related dependencies are among the best-tracked objects in syntactic analysis. Case, agreement, and related morphosyntactic mechanisms provide fine-grained diagnostics for how such dependencies are distributed and interact with grammatical structure. Discourse-based approaches, in turn, account for how reference is recovered and maintained even where local realization is reduced or displaced.

What unifies these otherwise diverse perspectives is not a shared theory of argumenthood, but a shared architectural assumption. Argument positions are taken to be part of the grammatical representation, and grammatical mechanisms operate over them. Their existence is inferred from their effects—through patterns of realization, interaction, and interpretation—rather than made explicit as an object of the grammar itself.

The diagnostic claim pursued in this section is therefore not a critique of individual analyses. Rather, it concerns a level of representation that remains largely implicit across approaches. Existing mechanisms regulate how arguments behave, where they surface, or how they are interpreted, but they do not define the conditions under which argument dependencies come into existence as part of grammatical structure.

This architectural silence has systematic consequences. Phenomena such as argument omission, generic interpretation, and persistent ambiguity tend to be treated as exceptional or reparative, precisely because visible arguments are taken to occupy determinate clause-internal positions. The following subsections examine the most influential diagnostic traditions, isolating both the insights they provide and the shared assumptions on which they rely.

2.1. θ -Roles and Lexical Argument Structure

One of the most enduring approaches to argument structure is based on thematic roles. Across the diverse frameworks discussed below, a common assumption can be identified at the outset: arguments are taken to be grammatically primitive elements to which interpretive relations are assigned. Theoretical variation primarily concerns how these relations are structured or realized, rather than how argumental dependencies themselves are established in the grammar.

Within early Government and Binding theory and later minimalist formulations (Chomsky 1981, 1995), θ -roles are conceived as interpretive relations between predicates and their dependents, constrained by the θ -Criterion and tightly linked to structural positions in the syntactic representation. This line of work establishes the foundational idea that predicates impose stable requirements on the number and type of dependencies they enter into—an insight that remains central even as the formal machinery evolves.

Subsequent refinements maintain this core intuition while rethinking the internal organization of argument structure. Grimshaw's (1990) theory introduces a hierarchy of argument prominence that systematically correlates with syntactic realization, while Dowty's (1991) proto-role approach replaces discrete role labels with bundles of semantic properties that guide linking. Both approaches underscore that argument positions are not arbitrary but internally differentiated, even though they remain presupposed as part of the predicate's structural profile.

Closely related are lexicalist accounts that locate argument structure in the lexical representation of the verb. Hale and Keyser (1993) argue that verbs are associated with structured lexical configurations that determine the number and type of arguments they select, with syntactic structure reflecting these properties. Pesetsky (1995) further develops this perspective by emphasizing the role of syntactic configuration in mediating thematic interpretation, while retaining the assumption that argument structure is lexically anchored. A shared consequence of these approaches is the robust generalization that predicates project a fixed set of argumental dependencies whose surface realization may vary.

Linking-based theories extend this view by deriving argument realization from event structure and lexical semantic constraints (Levin & Rappaport Hovav 1995, 2005). Here, alternations in syntactic realization are systematically tied to differences in event representation, while the underlying argumental dependencies are held constant. This work reinforces a crucial distinction between the stability of argument structure and the variability of its morphosyntactic expression.

A significant shift away from strictly lexicalist conceptions is proposed by Kratzer (1996), who argues that external arguments are not introduced by the verb but by independent functional structure. This move separates the source of certain argumental dependencies from the lexical predicate and establishes an architectural asymmetry between internal and external arguments. At the same time, the empirical motivation for this separation — namely the systematic variability in the realization of external arguments — does not in itself force the conclusion that their grammatical source is independent of the predicate. It leaves open the alternative possibility that such variation reflects differences in how a predicate's argumental dependency is structurally integrated, rather than where it is projected.

Subsequent work develops this insight into a more articulated syntactic theory of argument introduction. Most notably, Pykkänen (2008) argues that functional heads such as Voice and applicatives serve as dedicated sites for introducing specific argument types, yielding a fine-grained typology of argument introduction. While this approach provides a powerful and empirically well-supported account of argument-related asymmetries, it likewise does not uniquely determine whether such asymmetries require distinct grammatical sources of argumental dependencies. An alternative remains that the observed variation reflects differences in the structural integration of relations whose basis still remains at the level of the verb.

Taken together, these approaches converge on several substantive insights. Argument-related dependencies are tightly constrained by the predicate and its associated structure, and distinct argument positions may differ systematically in their grammatical properties, even within a single predicate. Their morphosyntactic realization, however, is subject to systematic variation. At the same time, the different approaches share the foundational assumption that argument positions themselves function as grammatical primitives. The present discussion builds on the former set of insights while taking the latter as an open architectural question.

2.2. Case-Based Licensing

A second influential tradition locates the licensing of arguments in the domain of case. Across the approaches discussed below, a shared assumption can be identified: argument positions are taken to be part of the grammatical representation independently of case, while case serves to regulate their syntactic visibility and distribution. Variation within this tradition concerns how case is assigned or realized, rather than how argumental dependencies are brought into existence.

Within classical case theory, nominal expressions are required to receive abstract or morphological case in order to be syntactically visible. Case-based accounts have therefore played a central role in explaining why certain nominal positions are obligatory, why others are excluded, and why particular configurations give rise to ungrammaticality. A decisive conceptual shift is introduced by Marantz (1991), who reconceptualizes case as a reflex of structural configuration rather than as an encoding of thematic relations, thereby severing case from semantic role assignment.

Subsequent work situates case assignment within an increasingly articulated clausal structure. Pollock's (1989) analysis of functional projections provides the foundation for locating case within specific structural domains, making case availability sensitive to syntactic position rather than lexical content. On this view, argument positions are often identified indirectly: a nominal expression counts as licensed if it occupies a position where case can be assigned.

Research on reduced or deficient nominal expressions further refines this picture. Cardinaletti and Starke (1999) show that different degrees of nominal deficiency correlate with restricted positional

possibilities and reduced case visibility, demonstrating that case interacts systematically with the internal properties of nominal expressions rather than simply marking argumenthood.

Despite their differences, these approaches converge on a common conclusion. Case operates over argument positions that are already grammatically represented: it renders them visible, filters illicit configurations, and constrains their morphosyntactic realization, but it does not itself introduce argumental dependencies. This conclusion is maintained in later Minimalist implementations that treat case as a reflex of Agree (Chomsky 2000, 2001), where case remains a condition on nominal visibility rather than a mechanism that constructs argument structure. The persistence of argument interpretation in configurations where case is absent or neutralized further underscores that case cannot be the source of argumenthood.

Taken together, case-based approaches provide a precise and empirically well-supported account of the structural conditions under which nominal expressions become syntactically visible and functionally distinguishable. They correctly diagnose how argument positions are regulated and externalized in syntax. What they do not provide is an account of how argumental dependencies exist prior to, and independently of, their case realization.

2.3. Agreement as a Diagnostic, not a Generator

If Case is understood as a reflex of structural dependency under Agree, agreement phenomena instantiate the same underlying diagnostic relation in a more general form. Across the approaches discussed below, a common assumption emerges: agreement presupposes the existence of syntactic units whose formal features can be matched or valued, and variation within this tradition primarily concerns how such feature relations are constrained or morphologically realized, rather than how argumental dependencies themselves are introduced into the grammar.

In typological and theoretical work, agreement has been shown to reflect systematic relations between predicates and their dependents. In particular, Baker (2008) places agreement at the center of his account of morphosyntactic alignment, arguing that agreement patterns reveal how arguments interact with verbal structure across languages. On this view, agreement provides a window into the organization of argument structure, making relational dependencies morphologically visible.

More recent formal approaches model agreement as feature matching or valuation under locality constraints. Accounts developed by Nevins (2011) treat agreement as an operation that relates already established syntactic objects by matching formal features such as person and number. While differing in technical implementation, these models converge on the view that agreement operates over pre-existing structures, rather than creating argument positions as such.

From a broader typological perspective, Corbett (2006) likewise characterizes agreement as a morphosyntactic reflex of established dependencies between controllers and targets. Agreement systems are shown to vary widely in their expression and complexity, but they uniformly presuppose the availability of elements whose features can enter into agreement relations.

Crucially, agreement-based analyses also provide evidence that agreement is neither obligatory nor uniformly correlated with argument licensing. As argued by Preminger (2014), agreement may fail, be reduced, or be entirely absent without causing the derivation to crash or the argument interpretation to disappear. Such cases demonstrate that agreement cannot be equated with argument licensing itself but instead reflects relations among dependencies whose grammatical existence is independently secured.

Taken together, agreement-based approaches correctly identify systematic patterns of feature matching between syntactic units and thereby provide a powerful diagnostic for argument-related dependencies. They show how dependency relations can become morphologically visible and typologically structured without themselves constituting the grammatical basis of argumenthood. What remains unaddressed is how such dependencies come into existence as grammatical objects, independently of the agreement relations that may or may not reflect them.

2.4. Null Arguments and Parametric Accounts

The preceding sections have examined how grammatical mechanisms diagnose argument-related dependencies once such dependencies are structurally visible. In these configurations, argument-related relations are tracked through overt syntactic material and their interaction with morphosyntactic operations. Null argument constructions bring this diagnostic perspective into question. Across languages, arguments may fail to be overtly realized under specific structural or morphological conditions, giving rise to patterns traditionally subsumed under the heading of *pro-drop*. A common assumption across this literature is that the grammatical availability of arguments is tightly linked to their realization, such that the absence of overt material requires special licensing mechanisms.

Classic work by Rizzi (1982) formalizes cross-linguistic variation in null subjects in terms of parametric differences, relating their availability to properties of inflectional systems and clause structure. Within this framework, null arguments are treated as grammatically licensed under well-defined conditions, while their absence elsewhere is associated with ungrammaticality.

Subsequent work refines this typological picture without altering its architectural foundations. In particular, Roberts (2010, 2019) develops a fine-grained classification of null subject systems, relating them to the distribution of ϕ -features and D-features. These approaches successfully capture robust cross-linguistic generalizations and predict clusters of syntactic properties associated with different types of *pro-drop*.

At the same time, null arguments are consistently treated as exceptional configurations rather than as ordinary instances of argumenthood. Whether analyzed in terms of null pronouns, empty categories, or parameter-dependent omissions, their existence is explained by reference to additional licensing conditions that permit an argument position to remain unrealized. What remains implicit in these accounts is why the underlying dependency should require such exceptional treatment in the first place.

This asymmetry becomes particularly salient when viewed alongside independent evidence that grammatical dependencies can persist in the absence of their usual morphosyntactic reflexes. As argued by Preminger (2014) for agreement, the failure of a diagnostic operation does not entail the absence of the dependency it typically reflects. From this perspective, the absence of overt realization in *pro-drop* configurations does not in itself motivate treating null arguments as ontologically special but instead invites a separation between dependency existence and the conditions governing its realization.

Later refinements of null argument typology—including parameter-based reconceptualizations by Jaeggli and Safir (1989), analyses of null objects (Rizzi 1986), and more recent work on partial and discourse-sensitive *pro-drop* (e.g. Holmberg 2010)—continue to enrich the descriptive landscape while preserving the assumption that argument positions are grammatically given and that their non-realization requires special explanation.

Taken together, parametric approaches to null arguments correctly capture cross-linguistic regularities in the distribution of omitted arguments. At the same time, they implicitly assume that argumenthood is tied to overt realization in fixed, predicate-adjacent positions. From this perspective, null arguments appear exceptional; once this assumption is questioned, their apparent absence no longer requires special ontological treatment. The present proposal takes this notion as one crucial point of departure.

2.5. Discourse-Based and Interface Approaches

The previous discussion of null arguments has shown that the absence of overt material in the clause does not by itself imply the absence of an underlying dependency. One response to this observation treats discourse as a strategy of referential recovery: rather than attributing such configurations to

special grammatical mechanisms, discourse-based approaches locate the resolution of argument interpretation in contextual accessibility, salience, and anaphoric continuity. On this view, discourse does not determine whether a dependency exists but provides the means by which reference can be recovered when grammatical realization is not locally expressed.

Within dynamic semantic frameworks associated with Heim (1982), reference is treated as inherently context-sensitive. Nominal expressions are interpreted relative to an evolving discourse representation, with meaning modeled as context change rather than as a direct mapping from syntactic structure to referents. A central contribution of this framework is the principled distinction between expressions that introduce new discourse referents and expressions—most transparently pronouns—that require access to an already established referent in order to be interpretable. Referential interpretation is thus dissociated from local syntactic realization, while remaining tightly constrained by discourse structure.

Related interface-oriented work, including that of Partee (1984), sharpens this dissociation by arguing that syntactic representations may be semantically underspecified on a systematic basis. On Partee’s view, compositional interpretation does not require that all argument relations be fully resolved within the narrow syntax. Instead, grammar provides a structured but incomplete semantic object whose interpretation is completed through interaction with pragmatic reasoning and discourse coherence. This perspective highlights that underdetermination is not a failure of grammatical licensing, but a regular property of the syntax–semantics interface.

This general picture is further elaborated in discourse-representational and accessibility-based frameworks. In Discourse Representation Theory (Kamp & Reyle 1993), discourse referents persist across sentence boundaries and remain available for later interpretation, subject to structural constraints on accessibility. General Accessibility-based accounts such as Ariel’s (1990) theory and the Givenness Hierarchy proposed by Gundel et al. (1993) focus on how different referential forms signal degrees of discourse accessibility. Reduced expressions function here as diagnostics for how strongly interpretation relies on previously organized discourse structure rather than on locally realized grammatical material.

Taken together, discourse-based approaches converge on several complementary insights. They show that argument interpretation need not coincide with the local morphosyntactic expression of a dependency, that referential identification is a distinct process from grammatical licensing, and that reduced or underspecified forms systematically exploit the availability of prior discourse structure. At the same time, these approaches presuppose a crucial grammatical condition: for definite reference to be interpretable at all, referential material must *at some point* be overtly introduced into the discourse. Discourse mechanisms can preserve, reactivate, and reidentify referents, but they cannot supply them independently of such explicit introduction.

From an architectural perspective, discourse-based accounts therefore motivate a separation between the existence of argument-related dependencies and the mechanisms that render them accessible and interpretable in discourse. The present proposal adopts this perspective by treating discourse as essential for referential identification, while maintaining that successful interpretation cannot proceed independently of grammatical structure, even when that structure is not overtly realized.

2.6. From Diagnostics to Ontology

The preceding sections have examined a range of approaches that address argument-related dependencies from different empirical angles. Despite their theoretical diversity, these approaches converge on a stable core observation. Argument-related dependencies are tightly constrained by predicate structure and remain interpretable even when their morphosyntactic realization varies or is not locally apparent. Across domains, these effects are systematic rather than exceptional.

At the same time, the review has shown that the mechanisms employed to capture these effects are uniformly diagnostic in nature. Thematic roles characterize interpretive relations once a dependency is assumed. Case regulates the visibility of nominal material without introducing dependencies. Agreement reflects relations among syntactic objects whose existence it presupposes. Approaches to null arguments explain when realization may be absent, while discourse-based accounts explain how reference can nonetheless be recovered. In each case, the relevant mechanism operates over dependencies whose existence is taken for granted.

This pattern points to a shared displacement of explanatory focus. Instead of addressing how argument-related dependencies enter the grammatical representation, existing approaches concentrate on how such dependencies are regulated or interpreted once assumed. As a result, argument positions function as implicit primitives: they are indispensable to analysis but rarely treated as grammatical objects in their own right.

The cumulative force of the diagnostics therefore points beyond their individual implementations. If argument-related dependencies are neither created by case nor by agreement, and if they are not constituted by null licensing or discourse interpretation, then their existence must be grounded at a more basic architectural level. What is missing is an explicit representation of dependency existence that is independent of the mechanisms that make dependencies visible or interpretable.

This diagnosis is necessarily retrospective: the fact that existing theories were not designed to articulate conditions on the existence of dependencies does not reflect an oversight, but rather a historically stable division of explanatory labor in which argumenthood itself was treated as given.

The following section addresses this gap. It develops a minimal architectural proposal in which argument-related dependencies are introduced as grammatical objects prior to the operations that regulate their realization and interpretation.

3. The Architecture of R-Anchors

3.1. Ontology and Terminological Commitments

The diagnostic review in the preceding chapter motivates the need for an explicit representation of argument-related dependency existence. Addressing this need requires treating dependency existence as a grammatical object in its own right. The present proposal therefore assumes a specific class of grammatical objects that underlie all argument-related dependencies. These objects are referred to as **R-anchors**. The term is not intended as a metaphor, but as a technical designation for a structural unit that mediates between predicate structure and reference. R-anchors are grammatical objects whose sole function is to encode the existence of a dependency introduced by a predicate, independently of how that dependency is realized or interpreted.

The choice of terminology is deliberate. The letter ‘R’ stands for ‘referential’, reflecting the core assumption that argument-related dependencies are dependencies that must ultimately be anchored in reference. At the same time, R-anchors are not themselves referents. The term anchor is meant to capture their structural persistence: once introduced, they remain available in the grammatical representation until their dependency requirements are resolved. In this respect, anchoring describes a mediating relation between predicate structure and reference, not a representational category such as argument or role.

The concept of R-anchors is directly informed by earlier work on R-loci in sign languages. In that literature, R-loci have long been recognized as central devices for tracking reference and regulating argument interpretation. Crucially, they make visible that argument interpretation relies on structurally persistent reference-bearing units that are not reducible to nominal expressions or agreement morphology (Lillo-Martin & Klima 1990; see also Cormier, Schembri & Woll 2013). In sign languages, this separation becomes particularly transparent, as referential loci allow dependency existence and referential identification to be dissociated in overt structure.

Building on this empirical foundation, earlier work has argued that such loci instantiate a more general class of grammatical dependencies (Nazar 2025). The present proposal takes this observation as a point of departure while abstracting away from modality-specific realization. R-anchors are conceived as modality-neutral counterparts of R-loci, capturing the same structural function without presupposing spatial realization.

A central claim of the architecture is that there is only a single object type involved in argument-related dependencies. No ontological distinction is drawn between syntactic units corresponding to argument positions, referential expressions, or discourse anchors. All elements that participate in argument licensing instantiate the same class of grammatical objects. What varies is not the nature of the object, but the way in which it enters the grammatical representation.

R-anchors may enter the derivation in two importantly different ways. Some are projected by predicates and correspond to what are descriptively identified as argument positions. These predicate-projected R-anchors encode the existence of dependencies introduced by the verb. Other R-anchors are introduced independently of verbal projection and function as carriers of referential information made available by the discourse. Despite their different sources, both types are subject to the same structural principles.

If predicate-projected dependencies and independently introduced referential resources are to interact in a maximally compatible and systematic way, the most straightforward assumption is that they are compatible from the outset. Treating compatibility as an emergent property of derivation would risk shifting the problem to additional mechanisms. By contrast, assuming a uniform structural format for all argument-relevant elements directly ensures that interaction can proceed without mediation.

On this view, predicate-induced dependencies and referential resources do not converge through special licensing relations, nor do they require conversion from one representational type into another. Rather, they are taken to instantiate the same underlying kind of grammatical object, differing only in how and when they enter the derivation and in which aspects of their internal specification are initially available. Interaction is thus not something that has to be engineered, but something that follows naturally from a shared representational basis.

The following section makes this assumption explicit by specifying the architecture of R-anchors.

3.2. Internal Structure of R-Anchors

The preceding section established R-anchors as a unified class of grammatical objects underlying all argument-related dependencies. This section specifies their internal structure. The central claim is that R-anchors are internally articulated and that this articulation makes it possible to distinguish the structural basis of an argument-related requirement from its eventual interpretive realization.

Each **R-anchor consists of two structurally linked dimensions: an index dimension and a reference dimension**. These dimensions are not independent objects or representational layers. Rather, they are integral components of a single grammatical object, each contributing distinct information to the representation of argument-related requirements.

The **index dimension** encodes formal identity. The notion of identity involved here should be understood in a strictly representational sense. The index component functions as an abstract label that allows R-anchors to be distinguished as individual objects within the grammatical representation. It does not encode relations between anchors, nor does it establish connections to predicates or nominal expressions.

In this respect, indices are not relational devices. They do not link anchors to one another and do not by themselves give rise to dependency structures. Rather, they provide a stable means of referring back to the same anchor across the derivation, independently of how that anchor may later interact with other grammatical objects.

Crucially, indexation does not itself introduce reference. An index may be present even when no discourse referent has been fixed, and it may remain stable across contexts in which interpretive resolution is delayed or underspecified.

The use of abstract indices is familiar from standard linguistic practice. For example, in sentences such as *Every student_i thinks he_{ij} is smart*, an index tracks the dependency between the quantified nominal expression and the pronoun without fixing a particular discourse referent. In such cases, indices are typically treated as notational devices introduced by the analyst. In the present proposal, by contrast, indexical identity is taken to be a structurally represented component of the grammatical object itself. What is usually left implicit is here encoded as part of the grammatical architecture. Indices encode formal identity information. Depending on the grammatical system, this information may be realized through ϕ -features, spatial coordinates, or other language-specific means of individuation.

The **reference dimension** encodes the capacity of an R-anchor to be associated with referential material in the course of the derivation. It defines the interface at which a structurally represented requirement may become interpretable as an argument. An R-anchor may therefore enter the grammatical representation with its reference dimension already specified, or without any referential specification at all.

Predicate-projected R-anchors instantiate the latter case. They are introduced without intrinsic reference and encode only the structural basis for an argument-related requirement. Referential information may enter the derivation independently and be associated with such anchors at a later point. The architecture thus allows the grammatical preconditions for an argument-related dependency to be represented prior to referential integration.

At the same time, the two dimensions are not symmetrical with respect to well-formed outputs. While referential information need not always be uniquely indexed in the output, a predicate-induced requirement cannot remain without referential integration. This follows from the role of predicate-projected R-anchors in encoding argument-related requirements: an unresolved requirement does not constitute an interpretable representation. A predicate-projected R-anchor that fails to be associated with referential material therefore cannot be part of a convergent output.

The internal articulation of R-anchors thus provides a minimal but sufficient representational format. By encoding formal identity and referential capacity within a single object, the grammar can represent argument-related requirements that are structurally present and identifiable, while allowing their interpretive resolution to be fixed only once appropriate referential material is integrated.

Up to this point, the architecture commits only to a single object type with an internally articulated informational structure. No licensing operation, no locality conditions, and no interpretive principles have been assumed so far.

The following section makes explicit how the internal structure of R-anchors introduced above gives rise to a limited but systematic range of specification states, reflecting the independent availability of indexical and referential information within a single grammatical object.

3.3. Specification States of R-Anchors

The internal structure of R-anchors defines a systematic but restricted space of representational possibilities. These states are static descriptions of how the internal dimensions of an R-anchor are configured at a given point in the grammatical representation.

The architecture allows four logically distinct specification states, depending on whether the index dimension and the reference dimension are specified or remain open. These states are defined purely in terms of representational configuration and are not ordered or evaluated with respect to well-formedness at this stage.

A first specification state is characterized by a **specified index dimension** combined with an **unspecified reference dimension**. In this configuration, an R-anchor is structurally identifiable and persistent, but does not yet contribute an interpretation. It encodes an argument-related requirement

whose identity is fixed, while its referential resolution remains open. Index specification in this sense does not itself introduce reference but makes an R-anchor available for identity-based structural relations.

A second specification state involves an **unspecified index dimension** combined with a **specified reference dimension**. In this configuration, referential information is present in the representation without being structurally individuated. The anchor contributes interpretive content but lacks a fixed structural identity that would allow it to participate in argument-related dependencies as a distinct unit.

A third specification state is defined by the **specification of both dimensions**. Here, an R-anchor combines structural identity with referential anchoring. Both the individuating and the interpretive requirements are satisfied within a single object, yielding a maximally specified configuration.

A fourth specification state is one in which **neither the index dimension nor the reference dimension is specified**. In this null specification state, no identity or referential information is fixed. The object encodes neither an individuated dependency nor an interpretive contribution but nevertheless instantiates the underlying object type made available by the architecture.

Taken together, these specification states delimit the representational space defined by the internal structure of R-anchors. Importantly, the specification states themselves do not determine how an R-anchor is introduced, how it changes over the course of a derivation, or which configurations are admissible as final outputs.

From a descriptive perspective, the specification states correspond to a range of familiar grammatical configurations, without being reducible to them. Anchors specified for index but not for reference are instantiated not only by predicate-projected argument requirements, but also by pronominal expressions, which encode structural identity without independently introducing reference. Anchors specified for reference but lacking index specification are reflected in elements such as bare nominals and mass nouns, which contribute referential material without being structurally integrated into predicate argument structure. Fully specified anchors correspond to configurations that function as stable and salient discourse objects, available for discourse tracking and relations of prominence such as topicality. These correspondences are descriptive rather than definitional and serve only to illustrate how the abstract specification states are realized across different grammatical domains.

The availability of a null specification state requires further comment. Its presence follows directly from the architectural assumption that index and reference are dimensions of a single grammatical object, rather than independent objects that are later combined. If index and reference were autonomous representational units, the grammar could introduce them separately and relate them by an additional compositional mechanism. Under such an architecture, a configuration in which neither dimension is specified would never arise: the absence of both would simply correspond to the absence of both objects.

The present proposal rejects this option. Index and reference within the model do not exist as free-standing grammatical entities. An index does not function as an independent bearer of identity but individuates an R-anchor and makes it accessible for structural correspondence. Likewise, referential information does not enter the grammar as an argumental object in its own right. In order to contribute to argument interpretation, it must be integrated into a structure that encodes an argument-related requirement. Argument-related requirements are therefore introduced as unified objects whose internal dimensions may remain underspecified.

Once index and reference are treated as genuinely independent dimensions of a single object, their specification must be allowed to vary independently. As a consequence, the architecture must also allow for the logical possibility that neither dimension is specified at a given point in the representation. The null specification state is therefore not a theoretical artifact or a placeholder for missing material, but a necessary outcome of the proposed internal structure. In particular, null R-

anchors should not be equated with null arguments or pronominal elements. Rather, they represent the most basic form of a predicate-projected R-anchor, encoding an argument-related requirement prior to any enrichment by identity or reference.

3.4. Verbal R-Anchors and Dependency Formation

The preceding subsections have characterized R-anchors as uniform grammatical objects with a fixed internal structure and variable informational specification. This subsection makes explicit how verbal predicates contribute dependency structure while leaving key aspects of informational specification open.

Verbs introduce R-anchors as part of their valency. When a predicate enters the derivation, it projects a determinate set of anchors, fixed by its lexical specification, which encodes the existence of the dependency relations it requires. These anchors do not directly correspond to syntactic positions, roles, or arguments. Rather, they represent structural requirements imposed by the predicate: relations that must be resolved for the derivation to converge.

Crucially, R-anchors projected by verbs are structurally *referentially open* at the point of introduction. That is, while they encode the existence of a dependency, they do not themselves introduce referential content. This property does not reflect a deficiency of verbal anchors as grammatical objects. Instead, it follows from the division of labor established by the architecture. Predicates contribute dependency structure, not reference. Referential material must therefore be supplied independently.

This asymmetry is fundamental. If verbs were allowed to project fully referential anchors by themselves, dependency existence and referential interpretation would collapse into a single operation. The grammar would then be unable to represent dependencies whose interpretation is delayed, underspecified, or ambiguous. The systematic separation between dependency projection and referential specification thus requires verbal R-anchors to enter the derivation without resolved reference.

At the same time, verbal R-anchors are not informationally inert. A predicate may contribute indexical information to the anchors it projects, drawing on formal distinctions encoded in verbal inflection or related morphosyntactic resources. Where present, such information contributes to the index dimension of an anchor without determining its referential value.

Crucially, verbal R-anchors vary with respect to whether and to what extent their index dimension is pre-specified by the predicate. This variation arises not only across different verbs, but also among the multiple anchors projected by a single verb. A predicate may provide indexical differentiation for some of its anchors while leaving others entirely unspecified.

This pattern is familiar from the distribution of overt morphological material on the verb. Even where a predicate introduces multiple dependencies, only a subset of these typically receives distinct morphological marking, while the remaining dependencies are nevertheless projected as part of the verb's argument structure without being individually distinguished at the level of verbal morphology.

The presence of indexical information is therefore not a prerequisite for verbal argumenthood. Verbal R-anchors may function as fully legitimate argument-related dependencies even when their index dimension remains open. Anchors without index specification are not marginal or exceptional cases but constitute a regular and widespread instantiation of verbal argument structure. Verbal R-anchors are thus best characterized as *structurally present but referentially incomplete* at the point of projection.

This property sharply distinguishes verbal R-anchors from anchors introduced by nominal expressions, which contribute referential material without projecting dependency structure. Fully specified R-anchors arise only once both indexical and referential information are integrated, yielding stable discourse objects. All three configurations instantiate the same grammatical object type, but they enter the derivation in systematically different specification states.

The consequence of this configuration is immediate. Because verbal R-anchors encode dependency existence independently of referential completion, the grammar must provide a way of integrating them with referential material introduced elsewhere in the representation. Referential completion is therefore not an optional enrichment or a matter of interpretation alone, but a structural requirement imposed by the nature of verbal dependency projection.

What remains to be explained is how R-anchors are related to one another and how referential incompleteness is resolved. The next section addresses this issue by introducing **Anchor-Checking** as the sole grammatical operation responsible for completing verbal dependencies.

4. Anchor-Checking and Dependency Completion

4.1. Why a Completion Operation is Required

If argument-related dependencies are represented independently of their realization, the grammar must specify how such dependencies are brought to completion. The preceding section has shown that verbs project R-anchors that encode dependency existence while remaining referentially open. This configuration is not an accidental property of particular predicates, but a necessary consequence of the architectural separation between dependency projection and referential specification. At this point, however, the system remains incomplete. If dependencies may be projected without reference, the grammar must provide a way of resolving this incompleteness.

The need for a completion operation follows directly from two assumptions already established. First, R-anchors are grammatically real objects whose internal dimensions must ultimately be specified for a derivation to converge. Second, predicates themselves do not introduce referential content. Together, these assumptions imply that referential completion cannot be guaranteed at the point of dependency projection. Without an additional grammatical mechanism, verbal R-anchors would remain structurally present but interpretively inert.

One possible response would be to attribute completion to interpretation or discourse alone. On such a view, the grammar would merely project dependencies, leaving their resolution to pragmatic inference or contextual accommodation. However, this move would undermine the core architectural distinction developed in this paper. If discourse could freely supply completion independently of grammatical constraints, the grammar would lose its ability to distinguish between licit and illicit dependency configurations. Structural failure would be indistinguishable from interpretive vagueness.

A second option would be to posit covert syntactic material that supplies reference internally, such as silent pronouns or empty categories. This strategy preserves grammatical control, but at the cost of multiplying ontological commitments. It reintroduces argument-like objects whose sole function is to simulate the effects of completion without explaining why such objects should exist in the first place. Moreover, it collapses the distinction between dependency existence and referential realization that motivated the introduction of R-anchors.

The present architecture rejects both options. Referential completion must be a grammatical operation, but it must operate over already existing anchors rather than introducing new argumental material. What is required, then, is an operation that relates separately introduced R-anchors to one another and resolves underspecified internal dimensions without creating new objects or positions.

This notion leads to another possibility: To identify completion with familiar feature-based mechanisms such as agreement. On this view, referential anchoring would arise as a side effect of feature valuation. However, this conflates three distinct components: the search for a dependency partner, the matching of compatible formal information, and the morphological externalization of that relation.

Agreement-based approaches are not misguided in locating a dependency relation between predicates and referential material. On the contrary, agreement correctly targets a structural relation that is central to dependency completion. Within the model, this corresponds to the matching of

indexical information between two grammatical objects. In this sense, agreement does point in the right direction.

However, agreement identifies only a highly restricted subclass of completion configurations. It conflates the existence of a dependency with a specific resolution outcome in which indexical identity is fixed and morphologically externalized. As a result, agreement-based mechanisms can capture only those cases in which dependency completion proceeds via shared and overtly realized indexical specification.

This restriction has immediate empirical consequences. Configurations involving generic reference, persistent ambiguity, indexical underspecification, or the absence of overt morphology systematically fall outside the scope of agreement-based licensing. In such cases, dependencies may be structurally completable without yielding agreement effects. Treating agreement as the core licensing mechanism therefore mischaracterizes its empirical reach.

Thus, an operation is needed that generalizes over these cases by isolating the dependency-search component that agreement correctly identifies, while decoupling it from indexical matching and morphological realization. Agreement thus emerges not as a competing mechanism, but as a morphologically privileged reflex of a particularly transparent checking configuration.

A more generalized checking operation that addresses these issues must satisfy a small set of basic requirements. It must be capable of integrating referential material introduced by nominal expressions with dependencies projected by verbs. It must be structural rather than interpretive, determining conditions on grammatical convergence rather than preferred readings. Finally, it must apply uniformly across configurations, so that apparent variation arises from differences in structural accessibility rather than from the availability of distinct licensing mechanisms.

These requirements motivate the introduction of a dedicated completion operation. The following section defines this operation—Anchor-Checking—and shows how it completes verbal R-anchors by matching their internal dimensions with compatible referential anchors already present in the derivation.

4.2. Anchor-Checking Defined

Anchor-Checking is the grammatical operation responsible for completing R-anchors. It applies to already existing anchors and resolves underspecified internal dimensions by relating them to compatible informational material introduced elsewhere in the derivation. Anchor-Checking does not itself create dependencies or add new structural objects. Its sole function is completion.

The following definition isolates the minimal logical conditions under which Anchor-Checking applies.

Anchor-Checking (definition)

Anchor-Checking is an iterative completion operation typically triggered by verbally projected R-anchors. The operation searches for structurally accessible R-anchors that provide specification for an underspecified internal dimension and copies the relevant information into the open slot. Anchor-Checking repeats until the verbal R-anchor is fully specified or no compatible anchor can be found.

Formally, Anchor-Checking takes as input two R-anchors. One anchor is informationally incomplete along at least one internal dimension; the other provides compatible specification for that dimension. The operation succeeds if the anchors are structurally accessible to one another and if their internal dimensions are compatible. Upon successful application, the relevant informational content of the providing anchor is copied into the corresponding slot of the receiving anchor.

Anchor-Checking operates strictly dimension-wise. Index information can only be matched with index information; referential content can only be matched with referential content. No cross-dimensional filling is permitted. This restriction follows directly from the internal architecture of R-

anchors and ensures that completion preserves the distinction between formal identity and interpretation.

The output of Anchor-Checking is not a new object. It is the same R-anchor as before, now with a more fully specified internal structure. Anchor-Checking therefore effects a change in informational state, not in ontological status. An anchor that undergoes completion remains the same grammatical object throughout the derivation.

Anchor-Checking does not require that all internal dimensions be resolved in a single step. An R-anchor may undergo multiple instances of Anchor-Checking over the course of a derivation, incrementally accumulating specification as compatible anchors become accessible. This allows dependency resolution to proceed stepwise and makes room for delayed interpretation and persistent underspecification.

For clarity, a distinction is thus required between individual instances of Anchor-Checking and the completion of an anchor. A single Anchor-Checking step may successfully copy information into an open slot without yielding a fully specified R-anchor. Completion is achieved only once all relevant dimensions of the triggering anchor are specified.

Crucially, Anchor-Checking is a necessary operation. For any R-anchor projected by a predicate, successful completion is a condition on derivational convergence. At the same time, Anchor-Checking is minimal. It merely defines the conditions under which informational incompleteness can be resolved.

This minimalism, however, does not come at the cost of unconstrained derivations. On the contrary, the internal structure of R-anchors sharply restricts when Anchor-Checking can apply. In particular, Anchor-Checking necessarily fails in three configurations: when both anchors are already fully specified, when both anchors are entirely unspecified, and when the relevant indexical or referential specifications are incompatible. In practice, indexical incompatibilities—such as mismatching ϕ -features or spatial coordinates—provide the clearest cases, but referential incompatibility blocks Anchor-Checking just as strictly.

Importantly, successful Anchor-Checking does not reduce to identity between anchors. Pre-existing identity in a given dimension may motivate or stabilize a successful match, but it is neither a necessary condition nor what defines the operation. Accordingly, Anchor-Checking is governed by negative conditions only: for the operation to succeed, it suffices that it is *not blocked*.

Put differently, Anchor-Checking succeeds whenever the available specifications do not impose incompatible requirements on completion. The operation does not introduce preferences among compatible outcomes and does not determine which of them is realized.

At this stage, nothing more is required. The definition isolates the minimal conditions under which informational incompleteness can be resolved, without committing to particular feature inventories, realization mechanisms, or interpretive effects.

With this definition in place, the architecture now includes a dynamic component that complements the static structure introduced in Section 3. The following subsections examine the different possible configurations and consequences of Anchor-Checking,

4.3. Structural Configurations of Anchor-Checking

Anchor-Checking applies whenever an R-anchor contains an unspecified informational slot that can be resolved by structurally accessible material. Given that R-anchors consist of exactly two dimensions—Index and Reference—successful checking always amounts to filling at least one open slot, provided that the available specification is compatible with what is already present.

Guided Completion: Partial and Full Specification

The most tightly constrained configurations arise when one anchor is fully specified along both internal dimensions, while the other is specified along only one. In such cases, Anchor-Checking is

structurally guided: exactly one informational slot remains open, and completion proceeds by evaluating the compatibility of the available specification.

In these configurations, Anchor-Checking is subject to a strictly negative condition. Checking is blocked if any feature that is specified on both anchors bears incompatible values. Features that are specified on only one anchor are irrelevant for the success of the operation.

Anchor-Checking therefore does not require exhaustive identity or feature valuation; it requires only the absence of conflict among shared specifications. When the shared dimension is the index dimension, identity constitutes the most transparent limiting case of compatibility. Both anchors carry indexical information, and Anchor-Checking succeeds when all indexical features that are specified on both anchors match. Mismatches immediately block the operation, as they impose incompatible identity requirements. This identity-based configuration corresponds to what is traditionally described as agreement.

Importantly, identity does not define guided completion. It represents a special case that arises when the set of shared specifications is sufficiently rich. More permissive configurations—such as partial overlap in specification or underspecification along non-critical dimensions—are fully compatible with the present architecture. What is crucial is not maximal matching, but the absence of incompatibility.

The same structural pattern is available in the opposite direction. Two anchors may both be referentially specified while differing in indexical completeness. In such cases, Anchor-Checking specifies the open index on the basis of shared reference. This configuration plays an important role in derivations where reference is initially introduced without full individuation and becomes structurally stabilized only in the course of subsequent grammatical operations.

Because guided configurations are characterized by a high degree of prior specification, they give rise to particularly stable completion outcomes. Their apparent determinacy follows from structural guidance rather than from the existence of a separate licensing mechanism.

Maximal Asymmetry: Null Anchor and Fully Specified Anchor

A second configuration involves maximal asymmetry between the anchors participating in checking. One anchor is entirely unspecified, carrying neither indexical nor referential information, while the other is fully specified along both dimensions. Anchor-Checking proceeds unidirectionally: the null anchor is completed by inheriting both dimensions from the fully specified anchor.

This configuration arises most prominently in radical null-subject languages, where verbally projected anchors may remain uninstantiated until they are resolved by an independently established discourse referent. The dependency introduced by the verb is completed by linking it to an existing referential anchor, without any need for index matching or additional structure.

Although this configuration often aligns with intuitions about ‘discursive’ argument licensing, it is structurally unexceptional within the present system. It differs from other guided configurations only in the distribution of specification across anchors. Anchor-Checking applies in the same way, and its success is again determined solely by the absence of incompatibility.

Complementary Specification: Index and Reference

Partly constrained, but equally well-formed, are configurations in which two anchors are each specified along one dimension, but in complementary ways. One anchor contributes indexical specification without reference, while the other contributes referential information without fixed indexical identity. Anchor-Checking succeeds by integrating these partial specifications.

This configuration is instantiated across modalities. In spoken languages, pronominal expressions often contribute indexical persistence, while bare or weak nominals contribute referential content without individuation. The same structural relation arises when a verbally projected R-anchor carrying indexical information is completed by an indefinite or weak nominal expression. In sign languages,

complementary specification is particularly visible in cases of spatial establishment, where referential material and indexical localization are introduced independently and subsequently aligned in form of salient R-loci.

What distinguishes this configuration from the guided cases above is the absence of prior determination in either dimension. Completion does not rely on identity, but on the mutual compatibility of underspecified information. As a result, Anchor-Checking here provides a structural basis for the introduction of new discourse referents without invoking any additional mechanisms.

Partial Completion: Null Anchor and a Single Specified Dimension

Finally, Anchor-Checking may apply in configurations where a null anchor is related to an anchor specified along only one dimension. In such cases, completion is partial: one dimension is resolved, while the other remains open.

When a null anchor receives specification by an indexically specified anchor, indexical individuation is established without referential anchoring. This configuration is characteristic of cases in which a null dependency is linked to a pronoun. The dependency becomes structurally identifiable, but reference is not yet fixed. Further iterations of Anchor-Checking are required for full convergence.

Conversely, when a null anchor checks a purely referential anchor, referential specification is achieved without indexical individuation. This configuration underlies interpretations traditionally described as indefinite or generic. The derivation and resolution of such interpretations will be addressed later in this article. At this stage, the focus is on the structural possibility of referential anchoring without indexical individuation.

Taken together, the configurations discussed in this section exhaust the structurally possible ways in which Anchor-Checking can succeed. In all cases, completion is regulated by the same principle: an underspecified dependency is resolved whenever compatible information is structurally accessible. Crucially, the operation does not impose selection among compatible anchors. When more than one completion is structurally possible, all such outcomes are grammatically licensed.

Ambiguity is therefore not an accidental by-product of the system, nor does it indicate a failure of dependency licensing. It follows directly from the existence-based character of completion. The grammar determines which completions are possible, but it does not decide among them. Any further resolution is external to grammatical licensing.

Furthermore, because R-anchors may be specified independently along the Index and Reference dimensions, completion need not resolve both dimensions simultaneously, nor must it proceed in a single step. Partial completion and stepwise resolution are structurally permitted outcomes of the system.

Given the availability of suitably specified anchors, these configurations delimit the space of possible completion outcomes. What they do not address is the question of how completion proceeds when no compatible anchor is introduced by the discourse. The following section turns to this case and motivates the introduction of a generic R-anchor as a structurally available source of completion.

4.4. The Generic R-Anchor and Generic Completion Configurations

The preceding sections have established that verbal predicates project R-anchors whose referential incompleteness must be resolved for a derivation to converge. Anchor-Checking guarantees such completion whenever compatible information is available. At the same time, the availability of discourse-introduced anchors is contingent. A grammatical system that requires completion cannot therefore rely exclusively on discourse individuation.

The R-anchor architecture resolves this asymmetry by assuming the availability of a **generic R-anchor**. The generic anchor is a fully specified R-anchor. Like all anchors, it comprises an index dimension and a reference dimension; crucially, neither dimension is left open. Instead, both are positively specified as ‘generic’. The index dimension encodes generic identity, and the reference

dimension encodes generic reference. Generic anchoring thus does not instantiate underspecification, or a weakened form of completion. It represents a complete anchoring configuration whose informational content is generic rather than discourse-individuated.

The availability of the generic R-anchor is not unconstrained. It does not function as a general fallback that applies whenever discourse-based completion fails. Rather, its use is subject to structural conditions that follow from the architecture itself.

Once generic specification is admitted as a positive value in both dimensions, the architecture predicts a fixed and exhaustively defined space of generic completion configurations. Given two dimensions and a generic value available in each, there are exactly three logically distinct ways in which a dependency may be generically completed.

The first configuration is **fully generic completion**, in which both the Index and the Reference dimensions are specified as generic. In this case, the dependency is neither individuated nor discourse-tracked, and no indexical identity is established. Crucially, this configuration is necessarily phonologically null. Because generic specification does not introduce an individuated index, there is no structural basis for overt index realization. Fully generic completion can therefore surface only through checking by null R-anchors, that is, as the result of completion without any overt material. In English, such configurations are typically detectable only indirectly, for instance through the absence of an overt object (*I already ate*). This yields a clear empirical prediction: languages that lack null R-anchors should not permit fully generic null arguments, since there would be no structural position in which a fully generic anchor could be realized.

The second configuration is **generic index completion**, in which the index dimension is specified as generic, while the Reference dimension is specified non-generically. Here, referential content is present, but the dependency is not anchored to an individuated, discourse-tracked index. This configuration may characteristically be associated with bare nominals and mass nouns, which introduce reference without establishing an individuated index.

The third configuration is **generic reference completion**, in which the reference dimension is specified as generic, while the index dimension is specified non-generically. In this case, an indexical position is established, but no individuated referential content is contributed. It is in this configuration that the appearance of expletive elements becomes relevant. Expletives can be understood as satisfying requirements on overt index realization while leaving the reference dimension generically specified. On this view, expletive material does not introduce individuated reference but rather provides an overt anchor for an index whose referential contribution remains generic.

These three configurations are defined purely in terms of internal anchor specification. Their surface reflexes are contingent on language-specific realization conditions and are not determined by the completion system itself. The present discussion is therefore limited to establishing the logical space of generic completion and its immediate architectural consequences. No claim is made that these configurations determine their overt expression, nor is a typology of realization patterns pursued here.

With the introduction of the generic R-anchor, the architecture developed in this chapter is complete. Verbal dependencies are projected independently of reference and are subject to obligatory completion via Anchor-Checking whenever compatible anchors are structurally available. At the same time, the analysis has made explicit what this completion operation does not determine. Referential completion concerns the internal specification of dependencies, not their overt realization or interpretive resolution. The following chapter takes up these consequences and turns to the question of how completed dependencies may—or may not—become visible in the grammar.

5. Visibility, Prominence, and the Consequences of Dependency

5.1. Null Arguments, Discourse and Structural Distance

The preceding chapter has established that verbal predicates obligatorily project R-anchors whose referential incompleteness must be resolved. At the same time, completion is defined as an internal condition on the informational structure of an R-anchor. The architecture itself does not impose any requirement that this condition be realized at a particular structural location, nor that it be expressed locally within the immediate domain of the verb.

This distinction has direct consequences for the grammatical status of nominal expressions. Under the present model, an ‘overt argument’ and a ‘discourse-bound referent’ do not correspond to distinct grammatical objects. Both are instances of the same structural element: a DP that is used to achieve the referential completion of a verbal R-anchor. What differs is not grammatical function or licensing status, but the structural position at which the DP is externalized relative to the verbal projection.

From this perspective, the traditional opposition between overt arguments and discourse-bound reference is misleading. The contrast is not dichotomous. Rather, it reflects a gradient difference in structural distance. A DP may be realized within the local structural environment of the verb, or at increasing degrees of remove from it, including positions that are conventionally described as discourse-level. In all such cases, the DP performs the same grammatical role: it provides the referential information required to complete the dependency projected by the verb. The notion of overtness therefore does not identify a distinct grammatical category, but merely a point on a continuum of externalization.

This reconceptualization motivates a different view on apparent argument absence. The lack of a locally realized DP in a canonical argument position does not indicate that a verbal dependency remains unresolved. Instead, it indicates that the DP responsible for referential completion is externalized at a greater structural distance from the verb. As this distance increases, the verbal structure may appear ‘argumentless,’ even though the dependency it projects is fully completed. The same separation also underlies surface patterns often described in terms of ‘subject inversion’: if the completing DP is not structurally required to appear at a fixed local position in order for completion to succeed, then variation in its surface locus will be expected, and can produce the impression of inversion-like alternations without positing any change in the underlying dependency.

Crucially, this analysis does not posit silent or implicit nominal expressions. Whenever a dependency is completed by an individuated referential anchor, the corresponding DP has to be overtly instantiated *somewhere* in the discourse structure. The apparent contrast between syntactic realization and discourse reference reduces entirely to differences in structural distance, not to differences in grammatical status.

There is, however, a single configuration in which no visible DP instantiation is required; When a verbal dependency is fully completed by the generic R-anchor. In such cases, completion does not involve an overt DP at any structural level, since there is no referential anchor to be externalized. The generic R-anchor therefore gives rise to the only genuinely null configuration admitted by the system: a completed dependency whose resolution does not correspond to an individuated discourse referent and hence does not require nominal realization. A direct empirical prediction follows: within the present architecture, all genuinely null arguments—in the strict sense of completed dependencies without any discourse instantiation of a completing DP—must be generic. This claim concerns the internal specification of R-anchors and does not preclude the possibility that referential material is supplied by means external to discourse structure.

Finally, the same perspective allows a natural handle on typological variation. Languages may differ not in whether verbal dependencies must be completed, but in how restrictive they are with respect to the structural distance across which completion can be achieved. Systems traditionally classified as “null-subject languages” can thus be reinterpreted as grammars that permit successful

completion with completing DPs externalized at greater distances from the verbal projection, whereas other systems enforce tighter locality conditions on the availability of completing material. This variation concerns the structural reach of completion, not the existence of a special null-argument mechanism.

The overall consequence is a sharp division of labor within the grammar. Verbal structure determines which dependencies must be completed; nominal structure provides the means by which such completion is achieved. Apparent variation in argument presence or position reflects differences in the structural distance at which the completing DP is externalized, rather than differences in whether a dependency is grammatically licensed. Subsequent sections will show how this separation gives rise to systematic effects of prominence and locality without invoking additional features or selection mechanisms.

5.2. Referential and Indexical Underspecification

The architecture developed in the preceding sections treats referential anchoring and indexical specification as grammatical dimensions of dependency completion. Both dimensions must be resolved for a derivation to converge. Crucially, however, the grammar does not require that all dimensions be resolved simultaneously or at a single point of externalization. Completion is evaluated over the course of the derivation as a whole. Intermediate states in which some aspects of a dependency are specified while others remain open are grammatically licit, provided that full completion is achieved by the end of the derivation.

This perspective has important consequences for the treatment of phenomena traditionally discussed under labels such as indefiniteness or delayed reference resolution. Under the present model, such phenomena do not indicate incomplete licensing or post-grammatical interpretation. Instead, they reflect the fact that the grammar permits different dimensions of a dependency to be specified at different points in structure and time, while still enforcing global completion. This temporal decoupling gives rise to systematic and stable configurations of partial underspecification.

Indefiniteness and Temporarily Open Index Specification

The following configuration concerns what is traditionally described as ‘indefiniteness’. In such cases, an R-anchor carries referential information sufficient to license completion, while the index dimension remains unfixed at the point of externalization. Structurally, the dependency is fully licensable: a verbal R-anchor can be matched with compatible referential material that satisfies its grammatical requirements. What remains open is not reference itself, but the commitment to a uniquely identifiable index.

From the perspective of surface interpretation, this configuration presents itself as an absence of indexical specification. It is precisely this absence that underlies indefinite interpretations. Importantly, an open index in this sense does not indicate missing reference or incomplete licensing. Nor should indefiniteness be equated with ‘non-definiteness’ or with genericity. Generic interpretations arise only when completion proceeds via the generic R-anchor, which corresponds to a fully specified but non-individuated form of anchoring.

Because indexical commitment is temporarily left open, an indefinite configuration remains compatible with later developments in the derivation or discourse. Subsequent material may introduce a fully specified R-anchor carrying the same referential content. When such an anchor becomes structurally accessible, it can participate in Anchor-Checking and specify the previously open index. In this way, an initially indefinite dependency may acquire a definite interpretation without any change to the dependency itself.

Indefiniteness thus reflects a transient structural state resulting from the temporal decoupling of grammatical dimensions. It does not require a special interpretive mechanism, nor does it correspond to a weakened or incomplete form of licensing. Rather, it follows directly from an architecture in

which referential anchoring and indexical individuation are grammatically distinct and need not be resolved simultaneously.

Indexical Specification without Referential Anchoring

A complementary configuration arises when indexical information is introduced in advance of full referential anchoring. This situation is particularly transparent in cases involving pronouns or agreement morphology. Such elements may supply indexical features that are compatible with a verbal dependency, even though no individuated referent has yet been established. In the present architecture, pronouns and agreement morphology do not introduce independent referential anchors but contribute indexical specifications that constrain and guide subsequent completion.

Consider a verbal dependency whose R-anchor is initially null. Encountering a pronoun may allow the index dimension of the dependency to be specified, insofar as the indexical features of the pronoun are compatible with the requirements of the verbal anchor. At this stage, however, the dependency remains referentially incomplete. The pronoun constrains how a potential referent must be identified, but it does not itself supply that referent.

As a result, Anchor-Checking cannot terminate at this point. The dependency is only partially specified, and the checking process must continue until a structurally accessible referential anchor is encountered in the discourse, now constrained by the indexical information provided by the pronoun. Only then can referential anchoring be achieved and the dependency fully completed. What appears on the surface as delayed or backward-looking reference resolution thus reflects a single, continuous checking process that integrates indexical and referential information at different points.

The illustrated configurations show that partial underspecification is an expected consequence of a grammar that evaluates completion globally rather than pointwise.

None of these configurations constitutes a failure of grammatical licensing. Both are compatible with the requirement that dependencies be fully completed by the end of the derivation. The grammar guarantees the existence and completion of dependencies; it does not require that indexical identity or referential information be fixed immediately wherever a dependency is externalized.

5.3. Apparent Topic-Prominence as an Effect of Completion

The preceding sections have shown that grammatical dependencies are licensed and completed independently of how, where, or whether they are externally realized. Referential anchoring is obligatory, but visibility is contingent; indexical specification may be delayed or remain structurally underdetermined. Against this background, an important question arises: why do certain referents nevertheless appear systematically stable or privileged across discourse, even in the absence of any grammatical mechanism that selects or ranks them?

This question is commonly addressed under the label of ‘topic prominence’. In many descriptive and theoretical traditions, topic-prominent elements are characterized as referents that exhibit exceptional accessibility, continuity, or apparent preference in argument realization. Such effects are often attributed to topic features, discourse roles, or language-specific parameters. The present architecture offers a different perspective. It does not deny the empirical reality of topic-prominence effects; rather, it explains why such effects arise without assuming that topic status is grammatically encoded.

Within the R-anchor model, apparent prominence follows directly from the mechanics of dependency completion. Fully specified R-anchors — anchors whose referential and indexical dimensions are both resolved — are structurally capable of completing verbal R-anchors in a single step. When such an anchor is structurally accessible, Anchor-Checking can terminate immediately, yielding a fully completed dependency without the need for further searching or integration of additional material. By contrast, partially specified anchors can contribute only to intermediate states of completion and will more frequently prolong the checking process.

This difference in completion efficiency has visible consequences. Because fully specified R-anchors can resolve dependencies without delay, they are more likely to be involved in stable, recurrent completions across clauses and discourse segments. At the same time, their maximal specification makes them suitable to complete a wider range of underspecified R-anchors. In this sense, fully specified anchors have greater licensing potential, not because they are ‘preferred’, but because they are maximally ‘checking-compatible’.

The cumulative effect of these properties is the appearance of prominence. Referents associated with fully specified R-anchors recur more easily, persist across structural boundaries, and appear to function as default anchors for subsequent dependencies. These are precisely the properties traditionally attributed to topics. Crucially, however, no grammatical operation assigns topic status, no feature marks an element as prominent, and no selection mechanism privileges one anchor over another. What is often described as topic prominence emerges as an epiphenomenal consequence of an existence-based checking algorithm operating over differently specified anchors.

This analysis also clarifies why topic-prominence effects are gradient rather than categorical. Because prominence reflects degrees of specification and compatibility, not membership in a grammatical class, it admits variation across contexts, constructions, and languages. Differences traditionally described as topic-prominent versus subject-prominent do not require distinct grammatical architectures. They can be reinterpreted as differences in how often fully specified anchors are structurally accessible for completion, and over what distances such accessibility is maintained.

This perspective highlights a central explanatory consequence of the present architecture. Phenomena often treated as independent — such as null arguments, discourse binding, indefiniteness, and topic prominence — follow from the interaction of obligatory dependency completion with contingent visibility and temporally distributed specification.

The following section situates these results with respect to locality and structural accessibility, clarifying how completion-based effects are constrained without altering the underlying architecture.

5.4. Structural Reach and Additional Grammatical Constraints

The discussion so far has shown that dependency completion proceeds by structural integration rather than interpretive selection. Because Anchor-Checking is sensitive to grammatical structure, it cannot operate over all referential material that may be available in the discourse. This section examines how the grammar constrains accessibility by organizing completion into local domains.

Within the present architecture, locality is captured in terms of structural reach. Anchor-Checking does not range freely over discourse representations, nor does it operate over all anchors that are in principle interpretable. Instead, it is restricted to anchors that fall within a domain of accessibility defined by grammatical structure. Domains delimit which anchors may participate in completion at a given point, without assigning grammatical roles or enforcing preferences. No specific theory of domains is presupposed here; the notion is used in a minimal sense to capture the fact that structural accessibility is grammatically delimited, without committing to a particular implementation of locality.

Structural reach therefore constitutes a necessary condition on dependency completion. A referential anchor that lies outside the relevant domain cannot complete a dependency, regardless of its discourse salience or interpretive plausibility. Conversely, any anchor that is structurally reachable and compatible may complete a dependency. Locality thus constrains accessibility, not outcome: it determines which anchors can be considered by the checking process, but it does not determine how completion proceeds once an anchor is accessible.

At the same time, locality alone does not exhaust the grammar’s means of regulating visibility and externalization. While structural reach determines *where* completion may take place, it does not determine *how* completed dependencies must be realized. In particular, locality does not fix which

dimensions of a dependency must be overtly specified, nor does it determine how different types of argument–predicate relations are constrained.

Two further classes of grammatical constraints are therefore relevant. First, restrictions associated with different thematic relations between predicates and their arguments may regulate how completed dependencies are externalized. Such constraints do not follow from locality and do not alter the checking mechanism itself; rather, they impose additional conditions on how dependencies traditionally associated with different thematic roles are realized in the structure. Second, languages may impose requirements on the overt externalization of indexical information for certain dependencies. Even when referential anchoring is structurally available, the grammar may require that indexical identification be made visible under specific conditions.

These constraints operate orthogonally to structural reach. They do not license dependencies or select among compatible anchors. Instead, they refine the conditions under which completed dependencies must be externalized, interacting with locality without reducing to it. Structural reach defines the space of possible completion; additional grammatical constraints regulate how completion is made visible within that space. The architecture developed in this chapter is compatible with such refinements but does not depend on them for its core explanatory claims.

Taken together, this chapter has shown how a minimal architecture of dependency completion accounts for a broad range of phenomena traditionally treated as independent problems. Apparent null arguments, discourse dependence, indefiniteness, ambiguity, and topic prominence follow from the interaction of obligatory completion with contingent visibility and structural accessibility. Locality constrains which anchors may participate in completion, while additional grammatical restrictions—such as those associated with thematic relations or indexical externalization—further shape how completed dependencies surface, without altering the core architecture. The following chapter illustrates the architecture developed here by walking through its possible completion outcomes, from simple completion to structural failure.

6. Demonstrating the Anchor Architecture

The upcoming chapter illustrates how the anchor architecture developed in the preceding sections behaves under a small set of representative completion scenarios. The purpose is not to introduce new assumptions or mechanisms, but to make explicit the range of configurations generated by a single licensing operation applied to a fixed class of grammatical objects. Each subsection presents a distinct end state of predicate–reference licensing, differing only in the informational sources involved and in their compatibility. Together, these configurations delineate the space of outcomes licensed by the architecture at this level of abstraction.

6.1. Simple Completion

The first case illustrates a minimal completion configuration in which a verbal dependency is licensed without indeterminacy. The purpose is not to establish a privileged or prototypical pattern, but to provide a neutral reference point for the configurations discussed in the following subsections.

A verbal predicate projects an R-anchor whose referential slot requires completion. The derivation also contains a single referential anchor that is structurally accessible and compatible with the specifications of the verbal anchor. When Anchor-Checking applies, the compatibility conditions are met and the dependency is established.

The result is a convergent derivation in which the verbal R-anchor is structurally integrated. No open dependency remains, and no further grammatical operation is required for convergence. The licensing relation is fully determined at the level of predicate–reference structure.

This configuration serves as a baseline against which non-unique, generic, and non-convergent outcomes can be contrasted in the remainder of the chapter.

6.2. Non-Unique Saturation and Structural Ambiguity

The following example illustrates a configuration in which Anchor-Checking succeeds without yielding a uniquely determined referential dependency. The purpose is to show that ambiguity is not the result of incomplete licensing or residual underspecification, but a stable outcome of successful structural integration under non-unique compatibility.

As in the simple completion, a verbal predicate projects one or more R-anchors that encode argument-related dependencies and are referentially incomplete at the point of projection. The derivation also contains discourse-introduced R-anchors that are structurally accessible for Anchor-Checking. Unlike the baseline case, however, more than one such discourse anchor is compatible with the informational requirements of a given verbal R-anchor.

When Anchor-Checking applies, each compatible discourse anchor satisfies the relevant structural conditions. No conflict arises with respect to indexical specification or other constraints imposed by the verbal R-anchor. As a result, Anchor-Checking succeeds. Crucially, the operation does not enforce uniqueness: the grammar requires that a compatible anchor be available, not that exactly one such anchor be identified.

The outcome of this configuration is a fully licensed dependency whose referential source is not uniquely fixed by the grammar. The verbal R-anchor is structurally integrated into the derivation, and no further completion steps are required for convergence. What remains open is not the existence or licensing of the dependency, but the identity of the referential anchor that ultimately determines interpretation.

In this sense, ambiguity arises as a direct consequence of existence-based licensing. Where multiple compatible anchors are simultaneously available, the architecture establishes the dependency without selecting among them. Structural integration is achieved, but interpretive determinacy is not enforced.

Non-uniqueness in this configuration is not restricted to the target of Anchor-Checking. A single discourse-introduced R-anchor may serve as a compatible source for more than one verbally projected R-anchor. Anchor-Checking does not consume or exhaust referential material; it establishes structural connections between anchors wherever compatibility conditions are met. Shared reference and convergent dependencies therefore follow without the need for additional mechanisms.

Crucially, the ambiguity observed in these configurations does not reflect partial or failed completion. The dependency is fully licensed within the grammatical architecture. Ambiguity emerges only insofar as the grammar does not impose constraints on the uniqueness of referential resolution. Interpretive differentiation, where required, is therefore orthogonal to the licensing operation itself.

Configurations of this kind correspond to cases traditionally described as structurally ambiguous or underspecified. Within the present architecture, such outcomes are not exceptional. They represent a natural end state of Anchor-Checking under conditions of non-unique compatibility.

The next section turns to a further relaxation of the baseline configuration, in which completion proceeds via the generic anchor.

6.3. Generic Saturation as a Non-Fallback Outcome

This section illustrates generic saturation as a fully convergent outcome of Anchor-Checking. Unlike earlier descriptive discussions of generic reference, the goal here is not to characterize a referential mode, but to demonstrate the status of generic anchoring within the running system.

As in the preceding configurations, a verbal predicate projects an R-anchor whose referential slot requires completion. The derivation may contain one or more discourse-introduced R-anchors that are structurally accessible and compatible with the requirements of the verbal anchor. Crucially, however, the availability of such discourse anchors does not determine the outcome of licensing.

The generic R-anchor constitutes a regular element of the system's referential inventory and is always structurally available. When its specifications are compatible with those of the verbal R-anchor, Anchor-Checking may establish the dependency by means of generic anchoring, independently of whether discourse-linked anchors are also present. Generic saturation is therefore not contingent on the absence of alternative referential sources.

In configurations of generic saturation, Anchor-Checking succeeds without remainder. The dependency is fully licensed, no slot remains open, and convergence is achieved. What distinguishes this configuration from discourse-linked saturation is not its licensing status, but the informational content integrated into the completed dependency.

Importantly, the architecture does not impose a ranking among compatible completion options. It does not require that discourse-linked anchoring take precedence over generic anchoring, nor does it treat generic reference as a repair or default strategy. Configurations of this kind underlie interpretations traditionally described as generic or impersonal.

Generic saturation therefore represents a stable end state of predicate-reference licensing on a par with uniquely and non-uniquely discourse-linked configurations. Nothing in the anchor architecture requires these distinct completion outcomes to be reflected in distinct surface realizations. Dependencies licensed via discourse-linked anchoring, generic anchoring, or temporarily unspecified anchoring may therefore be externalized in formally identical ways.

At this stage, underspecification, genericity, and ambiguity are no longer residual phenomena. They are licensed outcomes of the architecture itself and require no additional grammatical mechanisms.

The following section clarifies how derivational failure is to be understood within an architecture that deliberately maximizes the robustness of predicate-reference dependencies.

6.4. Structural Failure and the Limits of Predicate-Reference Licensing

The preceding sections have shown that the anchor architecture licenses a range of convergent configurations. Verbal dependencies may be resolved uniquely, non-uniquely, or generically, and the availability of the generic R-anchor in particular ensures that predicate-reference relations are maximally robust with respect to referential underspecification. Against this background, the role of derivational failure requires careful clarification.

At the level of verbal dependency, failure is not intended to serve as a general diagnostic for ungrammaticality. The anchor architecture is designed to model the establishment of predicate-reference relations in a way that minimizes unnecessary breakdowns. Its primary function is to determine whether a dependency projected by a predicate can be structurally licensed at all, not to enforce all constraints that may ultimately affect interpretive well-formedness or surface acceptability.

Derivational failure therefore arises only in a restricted class of cases: where no structurally compatible completion is available. This includes configurations in which a verbal R-anchor imposes requirements that cannot be met by any accessible referential anchor, including the generic anchor. In such cases, Anchor-Checking cannot establish the dependency, and convergence fails. Importantly, this notion of failure is purely structural. It reflects the impossibility of licensing a particular dependency at the level of predicate-reference relations, not the absence of reference or the incoherence of a potential interpretation.

Crucially, the rarity of such failures is not accidental. By treating generic reference as a fully licensed completion option, the architecture deliberately reduces the space of derivational breakdown. This should not be understood as excessive permissiveness, but as a consequence of the theoretical decision to separate the existence of dependencies from the factors that govern their interpretive resolution. As a result, many configurations that may later be excluded on the basis of word order, fine-grained index incompatibilities, or interpretive coherence can nonetheless involve well-formed predicate-reference dependencies at this level of representation.

From this perspective, a crash at the level of verbal dependency does not indicate that a desired interpretation is globally unavailable. Rather, it signals that the attempted dependency is not licensed as a predicate–reference relation within the anchor architecture. Where such configurations are excluded elsewhere in the grammar, this exclusion should not be expected to originate from Anchor-Checking itself.

Taken together, the configurations discussed in this chapter delineate the space of outcomes generated by the anchor architecture. Fully specified, non-unique, and generic completions all represent convergent states of predicate–reference licensing, differing only in the informational sources they integrate. Structural failure, by contrast, marks the outer boundary of this space and is intentionally restricted in scope. Thus, the chapter has demonstrated how a single licensing operation, applied to a fixed class of grammatical objects, yields a limited yet sufficient range of dependency configurations.

7. Conclusion: Dependency, Reference, and Architectural Commitments

This paper has articulated the architectural commitments required for a coherent theory of argument-related dependencies. Rather than proposing a new typology of arguments or refining descriptive distinctions concerning their realization, its aim has been to make explicit what grammar must minimally provide in order for such distinctions to be stated in the first place.

The central claim is that argumenthood is not a primitive of grammar. Verbs do not introduce arguments or assign roles in the traditional sense. Instead, predicates project R-anchors: grammatically real dependency objects whose defining property is referential openness. Whether such dependencies come to function as arguments depends entirely on whether they are structurally completed through Anchor-Checking, a single and invariant grammatical operation. Argument realization is therefore not a matter of choosing among alternative licensing strategies, but of satisfying a projected dependency under the accessibility conditions provided by the derivation.

By separating dependency projection from referential anchoring, the proposed architecture reframes a range of familiar phenomena. Apparent argument omission, instability of reference, and sensitivity to discourse structure no longer require special ontological categories. They follow from a system in which dependency completion is obligatory, while the form and timing of realization are contingent. Crucially, the grammar does not enforce immediate or unique resolution. Referential commitments may remain deferred without rendering the structure defective.

A direct consequence of this view is the elimination of ontological pluralism in the domain of arguments. The architecture does not distinguish between different kinds of argumental objects. Dependencies projected by the verb are uniform in their basic structure. What varies is how they are completed, and which referential resources are available when completion takes place. Cross-linguistic differences are thus expected to arise from constraints on accessibility and from the ways languages externalize completed dependencies, not from the availability of distinct licensing mechanisms.

At the same time, the architecture deliberately refrains from resolving a number of questions that have often dominated the literature. The present analysis does not develop a typology of null arguments, nor does it derive patterns of scope or definiteness. It also does not propose parameters regulating agreement or discourse binding. These questions are not set aside because they are unimportant, but because their formulation presupposes a clearer understanding of what grammar itself contributes. Without an explicit account of dependency existence and completion, such debates inevitably conflate structural requirements with interpretive outcomes.

Importantly, this does not mean that the architecture is neutral with respect to these domains. By treating argument-related requirements as referentially open dependencies, it provides a principled basis for distinguishing different kinds of apparent omission and different degrees of referential

stability. Whether a dependency is resolved through discourse-linked reference or through a generic source is not stipulated, but follows from the interaction between projected structure and accessible anchors. What the present paper leaves open is not the relevance of these distinctions, but their detailed articulation.

The same holds for the internal differentiation of argument-related dependencies. While no theory of thematic roles is proposed here, the architecture shifts the burden of explanation. To the extent that predicates impose differentiated requirements, these are expected to be reflected in the configuration of the dependencies they project, not in an independent inventory of roles. The contribution of the present paper lies in isolating the architectural space within which such distinctions can be stated without multiplying primitives.

In this sense, the contribution of the paper is architectural rather than descriptive. It argues that many familiar debates have been conducted against an impoverished background, in which dependency existence, referential anchoring, and surface realization were tacitly conflated. By disentangling these dimensions, the R-anchor framework provides a leaner and more explicit foundation on which more detailed analyses can be built.

If this reorientation is correct, then many of the empirical patterns that have motivated increasingly complex representational machinery can be seen in a different light. They do not demand richer primitives, but clearer separation of grammatical tasks. The theory of grammar, on this view, gains explanatory power not by adding mechanisms or objects, but by committing to fewer—and better defined—ones.

8. References

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